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Several LA-area DACA immigrants among those suing Trump administration

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SAN FRANCISCO — Six immigrants brought to the United States as children who became teachers, graduate students and a lawyer sued the Trump administration on Monday over its decision to end a program shielding them from deportation.

The lawsuit filed in federal court in San Francisco alleges the move violated the constitutional rights of immigrants who lack legal status and provided information about themselves to the U.S. government so they could participate in the program.

"The consequences are potentially catastrophic," said Jesse Gabriel, a lawyer for the plaintiffs. "These people can very powerfully and very clearly communicate the extent to which they organized their lives around this program."

The plaintiffs include teachers, an attorney, a medical student and a law student. They are from Mexico and Thailand.

They are:

Dulce Garcia, a San Diego attorney with a bachelor's degree from UC San Diego and a law degree from the Cleveland-Marshall College of Law in Ohio. Her family brought her to the U.S. from Mexico when she was 4 years old.

Viridiana Chabolla Mendoza, a Pomona College graduate who is now a first-year law student at UC Irvine. Her family brought her from Mexico to the U.S. when she was 2.

Jirayut "New" Latthivongskorn, a fourth-year medical student at UC San Francisco's School of Medicine who is also earning a master of public health degree from the School of Public Health at Harvard University. His family brought him to the U.S. from Thailand when he was 9.

Norma Ramirez is a Ph.D. candidate in clinical psychology from the Fuller Theological Seminary in Pasadena. Since 2016, she has worked at an outpatient clinic in Monrovia, providing school- and home-based therapy to patients in English and Spanish. Her parents brought her to the U.S. from Mexico when she was 5.

Miriam Gonzalez Avila, a teacher at Crown Preparatory Academy, an unaffiliated LAUSD charter school in the Jefferson neighborhood of Los Angeles. A 2016 UCLA graduate, she is earning a master's degree in urban education, policy and administration from Loyola Marymount University. Her family brought her to the U.S. from Mexico when she was 6 years old.

Saul Jimenez Suarez, a former college football player who is now a special education teacher, coach, and mentor in Los Angeles. His family brought him to the U.S. when he was 1 year old.

The lawsuit joins others filed over President Donald Trump's decision to end the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals program, which has allowed nearly 800,000 immigrants to obtain work permits and deportation protection since 2012.

More than a dozen states from Maine to California have sued over the administration's decision to phase out the program, alleging similar constitutional violations. So has the University of California system.

Gabriel said the impact of Trump's decision directly weighed on his clients' personal lives and decisions they made to advance their careers in this U.S.

He said San Diego plaintiff and attorney Dulce Garcia recently signed a lease for an office and hired employees because she believed she could stay and work in the U.S. under the program, Gabriel said.

"Now, the government is totally pulling out the rug from under her," he said.

Department of Justice spokesman Devin O'Malley blamed the Obama administration for starting the program and said the agency will defend Trump's decision.

"It was the previous administration's arbitrary circumvention of Congress that got us to this point," he said. "The Department of Justice looks forward to defending this Administration's position and restoring respect for the rule of law."

The Associated Press contributed to this report.

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